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You are listening to Travel Radio Australia. Today we pause our regular programming to pay tribute to one of Australia's greatest journalists and broadcasters, Darren Hinch, who passed away in July of 2026. In recognition of his outstanding contribution to journalism and public life, Darren was honoured with a Victorian state government funeral.

For me, this story is also deeply personal. Back in 1986, I had the privilege of working with Darren at Melbourne's top-rating radio station 3AW, where I was a young journalist. Like so many aspiring reporters, I learned a tremendous amount from watching Darren at work.

He was fearless, relentless in pursuing the truth, and always prepared to ask the questions that others wouldn't. It was an experience that helped shape my own career in broadcasting and journalism. In this special tribute, you'll hear moving eulogies delivered during Darren's Victorian state funeral by his former 3AW colleagues, Denis O'Kane, Tony Tardio and Craig Willis, who share their memories of working alongside one of Australia's most influential media figures.

We'll also hear heartfelt tribute from renowned television journalist, Ray Martin, together with touching reflections from Darren's third wife, Jackie Weaver, as family, friends and colleagues celebrate a remarkable life dedicated to journalism, broadcasting and public service. From everyone at Travel Radio Australia, thank you, Darren Hinch, for your extraordinary contribution to Australian media and for inspiring generations of journalists, including myself, RIP Darren Hinch. Just very quickly on a personal note, as Darren mentioned, I spent three and a half hours a day, five days a week for five years in the studio with Darren.

And in that time, we never had a crossword. Friends for 42 years. They made the comment to my partner, Donna, just the other day.

I said, they don't make them like Darren Nigel Hinch anymore. And for that, the world is a sadder place. You did good, my friend.

Rest well. And Pokari Karayana. That's a story for another time.

Darren always said, the only thing history owes the dead is the truth. Well, here it goes. Darren and Bette Midler engaged in a bit of horizontal romper after that interview.

And that is the truth. Hinch was a journalistic James Bond. Drama followed him everywhere, even to his first wedding.

In 1965, he was at a church in Sydney, waiting at the end of the aisle for his wife to be Lana. She was walking down, being escorted by her uncle. Halfway down the aisle, Darren heard a thud.

He turned to see the uncle collapsed and died with a heart attack. For any person, that will be enough drama for one lifetime. Not Darren.

In the years that followed, he would marry four times. Besack 16 times, get rich, go broke, get rich again, go to jail, get a liver transplant, become a senator and do it all as if it's the most normal thing in the world. Hello, everyone.

Jackie Weaver here, Darren's third wife and close friend for almost half a century. We stayed very close. In fact, he texted me the night that he died.

Most people do not like making speeches at funerals and I'm no exception. But Darren made me promise over and over and over again that I would. And so here I am.

And for me, Joby, goodbye. I love you, Joby. I've loved you from the very start to the very end.

Good night, sweet dreams. Good night, Joby. Now, another interesting time was at 3XY promoting the movie Xanadu.

You remember that one? All the disc jockeys went to the preview of Xanadu. And, you know, like music stations, they all get behind it and say, oh, what a wonderful show. Best show ever.

Go to see Xanadu. Well, Darren got on there the next morning and I'm going to quote him here because I wrote this down at the time because it was one of the many hinge quotes that you learned over the years. This is Darren.

I saw Xanadu last night. My recommendation, Xanadon't. Well, the program director and the publicity department at 3XY and also the movie theatre, they had heartburn, believe me.

Why can't we be honest about the dearly departed? When they depart, they used to ask. Why can't we tell the truth? So he did. What's it all? Fair enough.

So let me say a couple of things about his. He's had some strange quirks. At a restaurant, for example, he would always insist on the seat facing the door.

Always. That's so I can see if someone's about to shoot me, he used to say, or belt me over the head. It was always the case.

He'd say, what do you got that seat for? So I could see who's coming in. Towards the end, he accepted that he was a practicing alcoholic, as we mentioned tonight. And a practicing atheist.

So he wouldn't expect to be sitting up there listening to this today. He found, in those last few weeks when I spoke to him on the phone, he found Donald Trump appalling, as he did Pauline Hanson. Hinch went to jail for his convictions, as we all know.

He always fought for battlers and for underdogs. Yet, strangely enough, I never understood. He could never really understand the plight of Aboriginal people and the need for reconciliation.

It was his blind spot, if you like. He was against the voice referendum. He wouldn't have much

cared for today's welcome mark.

As beautiful as it was, welcome to country. It's all overdone, he used to say. I tried to get him to go bush with me, to see these shameful conditions in outback camps.

He said he would, but somehow he never did. But it is last year as a senator, I asked Hinch if he could get some federal government money for the Humpty Dumpty Foundation, a fantastic charity, which was trying to bring medical care to sick kids, Aboriginal kids, in the territory. So Hinch listened, he nodded, and he hit Malcolm Turnbull up for \$200,000, which we got.

He could be contrary. But anyone who knew him knows that he would have absolutely loved the idea of a state funeral today. So thanks to the Victorian government for doing it.

For a shit-stirring kid from Taraki, a quaint town best known for its forgotten world highway, he used to tell me, forgotten world hallway. A state funeral in this city that he called home, and which he loved, would have made him very proud. I think would have made him smile.

Now there's only one other thing extra, I think, that he would have demanded today, and that's a standing ovation. So let's give it to Hinch. As we say this last goodbye, please, a standing ovation for Hinch.

Thank you. I said that's life, and as funny as it may seem, some people get their kicks stopping on a dream. But I don't let it, let it get me down, cause this fine old world, it keeps spinning around.

I've been a puppet, a pauper, a pirate, a poet, a pawn, and a king. I've been up and down, and over and out, and I know one thing. Each time I find myself flat on my face, I pick myself up and get back in the rain.

That's life, I tell you, I can't deny it. I thought of quitting, baby, but my heart just ain't gonna buy it. And if I didn't think it was worth one single try, I'd jump right on a big bird, and then I'd fly.

I've been a puppet, a pauper, a pirate, a poet, a pawn, and a king. I've been up and down, and over and out, and I know one thing. Each time I find myself laying flat on my face, I just pick myself up and get back in the rain.

That's life, that's life, that's life. And I can't deny it many times. I thought of cutting out, but my heart won't buy it.

But if there's nothing shaking, come this year to life. I'm gonna roll myself up in a big ball, and I'm gonna fly. My, my.

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